# Four Nights and a Week Later

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# Four Nights and a Week Later

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

After a long day out at the ski lodge where they work at, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver are finally finishing their shift. It's probably their favourite time of the day since neither has to speak, only tidy everything up and leave without so much as a "goodbye".
Yet, this time… they find themselves stuck.
As a snowstorm rages on, the women are forced to spend the night at the lodge, perhaps longer, meaning they'll have to interact.
It will be quite awkward sometimes, funny, intense, and they might learn more about the other than expected… but perhaps it's not a bad thing after all…

» —You are…
» —Perfectly well aware that I should eat dinner now, not this— Shadow Weaver interrupted.
—But that won't stop me, because I don't care— she concluded, opening the chocolate bar.

Notes

WELCOME!

As my hands freeze in this lovely Thursday afternoon, I'm finally posting this Snowed In one-shot that could totally be a multi-chapter lol

Also, I have typed half of this from my phone since my cat ate the keyboard table WHILE I WAS EDITING
My gods… the insanity I've lived today…

Anyways, without further introductions, I hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the work for more notes

## Thursday night

It was finally that time.

With sunset came the end of the shift, and with the end of the shift came the sweet return home.

As Castaspella finished putting away the last of the equipment she had just finished cleaning, her head was already busy choosing what book to read that night once she got home.

Perhaps a light novel…

Well, she had enough time to decide while preparing to leave.

Humming a little tune, Castaspella put on her fluffy snow jacket, grabbed her backpack, and headed to the main hall, where she came across Shadow Weaver, the only coworker who remained with her until closing.

They *did* sometimes chat, yes, but overall it tended to be pure bantering; everything was a competence, like a constant tug-o-war they two had, measuring who won depending on who had the last word.

So it was no surprise that neither said a peep.

Shadow Weaver was ready to leave too. Having finished recording the earnings and spendings of the day, she promptly put on her large burgundy coat and gloves, and went for the door at the same time as Castaspella.

With a bit of a mocking smirk, she gestured at her to open the door, getting only a scowl as a reply before the young woman did as much…

And then their faces fell.

*Snow*.

So much snow!

—What the heck!?

—It's… all blocked!— Castaspella gasped, promptly closing the door again. —When did this happen!?

—The storm must have begun a while ago— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —I can't believe I didn't notice.

—This is just *great*!— the young woman complained, grunting.

—Did you have anything important to do tonight?— she mocked her, taking off her coat.

—Uh, yes… A very important *date* with a book and a cup of tea— Castaspella replied, rolling her eyes. —It doesn't matter if I had something to do! The point is: we're stuck here!

—That much is *obvious*— Shadow Weaver uttered, starting to get annoyed. —So if you could come to terms with it instead of starting to panic, it would be *great*.

—That's it!? You just-just resign to the idea of spending the night here!?— she exclaimed, finally noticing the woman had, in fact, made herself comfortable on a couch.

—Precisely. There's food to eat, couches to rest, even blankets to stay warm if the heaters don't last. What else do you need?— she condescendingly replied. —Ah, yes, your *book*.

Castaspella could only growl angrily at that…

Alright, she *was* right.

It wasn't the end of the world having to stay the night there…

Yet that wouldn't stop her from brooding.

Muttering to herself, she finally decided to take off her snow jacket and set her things on another empty couch before stalking to the kitchen for a cup of tea.

At least she could have that, no?

Once she had her steamy mug, Castaspella went to the dining room, sat on the large table, and took out her phone.

Low battery.

Good thing she had her charger with her…

But… No signal. *That* she couldn't fix.

Things only got *better*…

With a sigh, she left her cup and went for her charger, plugged it into the wall next to the couch she had claimed, and returned to the dining room.

She wanted nothing but to enjoy her tea in solitude… which wouldn't happen, apparently.

The old woman had sat right in front of her spot with something between her hands.

—You are…

—Perfectly well aware that I should eat dinner now, not this— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —But that won't stop me, because I don't care— she concluded, opening the chocolate bar.

She couldn't be for real…

—We have… *so many* things you could eat instead.

—I *do not* care— she insisted, taking a bite.

Patience.

She'd need so much patience to survive the night…

So she decided to ignore her and finally drink her tea.

Silence stretched for a while as each of them focused on their food, yet it was getting unbearable.

With the sound of the storm in the background, the awkward quietness felt *loud*.

Especially since Shadow Weaver kept glancing at her.

—Alright. What is it?

—Nothing.

—Really? Then why do you keep looking at me?

—Can't help it. You're the only thing moving around here. It's not purposeful— the woman answered, rolling her eyes.

As she got the last piece of chocolate into her mouth, Castaspella stared at her in confusion.

—The only thing moving… How- I don't understand what you mean.

—Reflexes.

—That explains *nothing*.

—I have no reasons to explain anything to you. Look it up yourself.

—How *annoying* can you get!?

—I'm not even bored yet— Shadow Weaver mockingly replied.

—Damn it…

Castaspella downed the last bit of her tea, already gone cold, and went to take the cup to the kitchen.

Now *she* would actually have some dinner.

The lodge was, fortunately, large enough that the women didn't have to stay in the same room for long, yet both ended up returning to the main hall as it was the only room with the heaters still on.

The kitchen and dining room were freezing now, so were the office and the restrooms. And forget the second floor…

Hence, once again, they found themselves sitting in silence, each on their couch this time, so it was slightly less awkward.

Slightly…

—Reflexes…— Castaspella muttered, trying and failing to look up on the internet what the woman could mean. —This is useless— she eventually grunted, resigned.

—Whatever shall you do without that extra brain on your hand to do all the thinking…— Shadow Weaver immediately mocked her, rolling her eyes before smirking at her. —No internet, right?

—Mean— she rebuked.

—Are you surprised?

—Of course not. But that was so *unnecessary*! You're obviously getting bored there…

—Oh, no. Looking at the ceiling is *so* interesting. You should try it— she replied, sarcastic, before laying on the couch and covering herself with a blanket.

—Will you be like this all night!?

—With some luck, I'll fall asleep… Supposing you stop cursing at your phone, that is…

—So *I* don't let you sleep!?— Castaspella scoffed, offended. —You know what!? *Fuck you*!

She couldn't take it anymore.

If the woman wanted to sleep, then so be it!

She'd just grab a blanket too, turn off the lights, and attempt to fall asleep as soon as possible.

Castaspella had never wished for morning to come faster…

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## Friday

Eventually, the young woman woke up, tired yet, and tried not to groan too loudly as she found herself still surrounded by darkness…

How early could it be?

Four in the morning? Maybe five?

It was better to check her phone, then… Or not.

*Half past eight*!?

Where the heck was the sun!?

Unless…

Castaspella pushed herself to leave the couch and stumbled a bit as she went to turn on the lights.

Just as expected.

—Why the heck did you turn on the lights?— Shadow Weaver immediately asked, groggy and notoriously annoyed.

—It's eight thirty!

—Sure…

—It is! But the snow completely blocks the windows!

The woman groaned and covered her face for a moment, then sat up on the couch and shook her head.

—You *do* understand what that means, right?

—The door…

—Exactly.

—So we're still stuck!?

—*Obviously*. It's probably time to try the landline…

—Of course— Castaspella agreed, letting out a sigh. —I'll make the call, you… turn on the heaters, please.

—Sure…

Surprisingly, Shadow Weaver complied, so the young woman could focus on getting some help.

Sitting in front of the desk in the office, she dialed a number and hoped for the best.

—Oh! Finally!— she exclaimed, hearing the voice of her niece on the other side. —Glimmer, Dear, I'm so sorry to bother you, but I need help— she began, without letting her speak. —

The snowstorm trapped me and Shadow Weaver at the lodge!

*—You spent the night there!?*

—Yes, and it only got worse this morning. Everything is blocked! The door and the windows too!

*—Auntie, why didn't you call before!?*

—I thought it'd be over by now, not- I just didn't think so much snow would accumulate.

*—A-alright. I'll get you some help, but… I can't promise much— Glimmer hesitantly replied.*

—Anything will be enough.

*—It's just that… the storm is still fierce over there, so…*

—It might take time for help to arrive, I understand— Castaspella nodded. —As long as it doesn't take too long… We can still wait another day, I guess…

*—You know how this is, Auntie. It can be* days*. Plural. Do you have enough supplies?*

—Food and drink, yes. As long as running water, electricity, and gas aren't cut, we should be fine for… a week, perhaps— she reluctantly admitted. —But *please* don't let it stretch a whole week. This is *insane*!

*—Is she giving you a hard time?*

—Very much. You have no idea…— Castaspella grunted, trying not to vent to her. —So, please, please, do whatever you can as fast as you can.

*—Of course, Auntie. Hang on there. I'll make sure a team is sent to rescue you as soon as the storm passes— Glimmer finally promised.*

—Thank you— she sighed. Then, suddenly remembering, she requested —Oh, one last thing: please feed my pets.

*—Oh, I… You know I'm afraid of them— her niece reminded her. —But I'll ask Adora if she can. Does Dad have your keys?*

—He should have the spare ones, yes— she confirmed.

*—Alright. I'll make sure they are fed while you're trapped there.*

—Thank you very much.

Dispirited, the young woman hung up and rested back on the seat while letting out a long sigh.

Alright. That was as much as she could do…

But it *certainly* wouldn't be easy to bear the next few days trapped in there with Shadow Weaver, so she really needed to think of some way to keep herself occupied.

When they both met again at the now-warmer main hall, Castaspella briefly went over her conversation with her niece.

—Yes. I went to the second floor and I could see the storm still raging outside— the woman nodded. —You can easily expect it to last long…

—Then *what* are we supposed to do!?

—First of all, you need to stop *panicking*— she reproached her. —We have enough supplies, and Glimmer promised help as soon as possible. So *stop* behaving as if we were going to die.

—I-I'm sorry, it's just…— Castaspella began, yet hesitated. What could she say? *I'm hating your attitude*!? —I am clearly not made for these situations— she finally decided to say.

—It's not as bad as you might believe— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes. —If your big problem is that you don't have anything to do, then I suggest going over the lost-and-found box. There might be something you can play with— she suggested, smirking mischievously.

—I… don't know what to think of that— the young woman admitted. —But, alright… I'll… check it out after breakfast— she accepted. —Now, I'm starving.

—As am I…

The women quietly walked into the kitchen together and, as if in silent agreement, Shadow Weaver brewed *two* cups of coffee, while Castaspella put together enough food for them both.

—Tha-thanks— she stammered, surprised by the unexpected generosity.

—Didn't think I'd pour you a cup too?— the woman asked, smirking.

—Not really.

—And yet you made enough scrambled eggs for me too…

—I- Well, yes. But…

—Take it as repayment, in any case— Shadow Weaver interrupted her.

—For what?

—The food, calling for help… you name it— she dismissed her, focusing on her breakfast.

Right…

Just repayment.

That's how she works, after all… No free favours.

After their food was gone, and the dishes were washed, Castaspella's curiosity got the best of her, and she decided to actually check the box of lost-and-found items.

—There is *no way*— she gasped, her eyes almost sparkling.

Wool and needles!?

Hold on…

Did she *know*!?

—I see you've found the grandma stuff.

And there came the mockery.

She had followed her just to make fun of her…

Not even surprising anymore.

—Funny. How did you know!?— she simply asked, confused.

—You keep gifting your niece those ugly sweaters you knit. I *reckoned* you like it— the woman replied.

—Hey! They aren't ugly!

—They are.

—Ugh, fuck off…

—You're welcome.

—Yeah, yeah. Thanks— Castaspella reluctantly let out, picking up the largest ball of wool and the pair of needles before putting the box away. —This should last me a while.

The morning went by in silence as the young woman knitted and Shadow Weaver rested…

The silence was more bearable this time since she was so focused on her knitting, and she ended up skipping lunch without noticing.

Only when Shadow Weaver got up for a cup of tea and a bag of cookies did she remember she should eat.

It was already late in the afternoon, according to the clock.

—Nothing like some tea after a good nap…— she heard her mumbling, right as she stepped into the kitchen.

—You actually slept half the day?

—What's wrong with that? It's not like we have *work* to do— the woman retorted, rolling her eyes.

—I'm just… surprised you can sleep so much…

—You have trouble sleeping, don't you?— she laughed. —Because it sounds like you're jealous.

—Oh, come on! Can't you stop being mean about everything!?

—As long as you give me things to mock you for, be sure I *will* keep annoying you— Shadow Weaver promised… or threatened.

—*Charming*.

Castaspella was, once again, indignant.

But she could do nothing other than watch her walk away with her tea and cookies.

And… there was some hot water left, so she could maybe have tea too…

A while later, the young woman had just finished washing her cup when she noticed some strange noise coming from the main hall, voices, and hesitantly went to investigate.

Fortunately, she wasn't going crazy.

It was just the radio; Shadow Weaver was fiddling with it…

—There you go…

—Oh, wow. It's working— she let out, surprised. —How did you manage to tune in to the news?

—I am not incompetent— the woman replied, rolling her eyes.

—*The cold front has arrived in the city as forecast…*

—I don't consider you incompetent! That's what *you* think of *me*!

—Oh, no… of course not. You're not completely incompetent. You're really good at *wasting oxygen*— she mocked her, smirking sardonically.

—Bitch!

—*...The strong storm is expected to last at least another two days…*

The insult was ignored in favour of the radio, and Shadow Weaver grunted —Just *great*.

—There's no way we're surviving each other…— Castaspella muttered, walking past her and going for her phone on the couch. —Still no signal. Ugh!

—Listen. As long as you *don't* invade my space, I shan't invade yours; I won't promise to stop the mockery, but I can try to tune it down *a bit* if *you* stop being ridiculous about everything.

—You're just insanely mean for *absolutely* no reason; I'm not ridiculous about everything, *you* just find a way to mock me no matter what I do!

—It's a gift— the woman replied, smirking.

—*See*!?

—Well, the lodge is big enough for us both to stay away from each other, so that's the alternative.

—We need to keep the heaters to a minimum, just in case, so they last. We can't warm up the whole lodge…— Castaspella pointed out. —Just… let's try to annoy each other as little as possible. Alright?

—Deal— Shadow Weaver accepted, albeit with a scoff. —In that case, don't use the water. I'll take a bath.

—Right, sure…

By the end of the day, and since she wasn't distracted by the old woman's mockery now, Castaspella realized something: her clothes. She hadn't changed in more than twenty-four hours now.

That first night, she slept with them on because she thought they'd be gone in the morning…

But now that there's a possibility they might have to spend a few more days there, she simply refused to keep sleeping while wearing her only set of clothes.

—Instead of being so dramatic about that, grab something from the spare clothes we keep here— Shadow Weaver reproached her, after bearing her complaints for a short while.

—What!? No! I-I can't…

—Why not? Everything is clean, warm, and *something* must fit you— she argued. —I was told you were smart, yet you haven't demonstrated as much in the time we've been trapped here— she added, rolling her eyes.

—Ugh, mean…

—I'm *not* trying to mock you *this* time. In fact, I agree. We shouldn't sleep in these clothes. But you're not *thinking*. Use your brain instead of focusing on how bad everything is.

—I- A-alright. Whatever— Castaspella resignedly accepted, standing from the couch to go for some spare clothes. She *hated* how right the woman was in this case. —But you didn't have to be so nasty about it…

—I could have been *worse*— she scoffed, sardonic.

That bitch…

Without another word, Castaspella finally left the room.

No use in further arguing.

It didn't really take her long to find a set of thermal clothes she could use to sleep, so she soon returned to the main hall. But she looked quite ashamed now.

While searching for a shirt and pants that fit her, she couldn't help reflecting on Shadow Weaver's words…

She was being *really* stupid lately, wasn't she? Panicking easily, unable to see the obvious sometimes, most times because she was also too busy trying *not* to jump on her when provoked, but… it suddenly occurred to her that, if she were alone, it'd be far *worse*.

Perhaps she had to be a little more thankful.

It was difficult with this woman, but… Ugh… She had to try.

Shadow Weaver had said she was told Castaspella was smart yet wasn't demonstrating it, so why not show her just how useful she can *also* be?

It might even earn her the respect of the old woman…

—Um… So…— she hesitantly began, turning to face her after setting down the thermal clothes on the couch. —What do you say I cook some lentil stew? I found enough ingredients for it, but it would probably yield about six portions, so it'd be too much for me alone.

—What's the catch?

—The catch is you have to accept before I change my mind— Castaspella hissed, already regretting it. Then, with a frustrated sigh, she admitted —Listen: you were right. I'm not

really thinking. I'm not being smart. I'd be having a harder time if you weren't here to talk some sense into me… But I'm not that useless.

—You want to prove your worth… cooking stew? It's a lot of work just to achieve that— the woman incredulously pointed out.

—It's not *that* much work. We have a rice cooker here! I can prepare it there, and it'll be done in an hour— she dismissively replied.

—What?

—I just have to cut the ingredients and put everything inside. The machine does the rest— she cheerfully assured her.

—I thought rice cookers were just for rice.

—Oh, no. They are *very* versatile!— Castaspella began, her eyes almost shining. —I have one at home. I prepare at least half my meals there! Soups, stews, sweet rolls for breakfast, savory rolls for brunch… It's a true lifesaver!

—You're *actually* fangirling over a machine?

—Perhaps— the woman giggled. —I just think it makes a lot of things much easier.

—Alright then— she smirked, standing from her couch. —Show me what you can do, and I might *consider* changing my mind about you.

—You'll stop making fun of me?

—Can't promise— Shadow Weaver scoffed, rolling her eyes. —You'd have to impress me. And that's very difficult.

—I'll take the challenge— she promptly accepted. —But I better begin now, before I start feeling hungry…

An hour later, the women were sitting in the dining room, each with a bowl of lentil stew, silently eating.

It was *good*.

Everything was properly cooked, it was a bit dry, but with some extra hot water, it could be quickly fixed, and even without keeping constant vigilance on the rice cooker, the stew hadn't burnt or anything.

It was… pretty much perfect.

—You win this round.

—I take it that you like it.

—You're resourceful enough, and this isn't half bad.

—How come your "praise" feels like some backhanded insult?— Castaspella complained, indignant.

—Consider yourself lucky I'm giving you *any* form of praise— the woman rebuked.

—Right— she muttered, clenching her jaw. —I can't believe I'm really seeking your approval…

—Hmm, yes. That's strange— Shadow Weaver snickered. —But it shouldn't be surprising. You're a people-pleaser…

—I am not- What's your problem!? Why do you hate me so much!?

She wasn't sure why it was affecting her so badly, but it was. Her reaction was actually louder than intended, and it left the old woman speechless for a moment.

—I should be asking you the same— she eventually replied, instead of answering the question.

—Who says I hate you!?

That made Shadow Weaver scoff and squint at her as she rebuked —Is your memory that poor?

—Now *what* are you talking about!?

It seemed like she really had no idea.

—Forget it…— she spat, regretting having said anything. She then stood up, picked up her bowl, and made her way back to the kitchen, muttering —Ignorance is bliss…

Castaspella had honestly not even the faintest idea of what she was talking about.

And now she was curious but… the woman refused to explain anything.

Instead, she handled the dishes and put away the leftover stew, insisting it was "only fair".

Once again, no free favours.

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## Saturday

The following morning, the women were startled awake by the ringing of the landline.

—I'll go! I'll go…— Castaspella promptly said, struggling to get up and unsteadily making her way to the office. Once there, she flopped down on the chair in front of the desk and

picked up. —Hello?

*—Auntie! Good morning!*

—Hmm… What time is it?

*—It's like ten in the morning— Glimmer replied, giggling. —Did I wake you up?*

—Yeah… It's all so dark here…— she yawned. —Do you have good news?— she then asked, hopeful albeit still sleepy.

*—I'm sorry, Auntie. It's the opposite…*

—What!?— Castaspella reacted, opening her eyes wide.

That did wake her up…

*—Listen: Mom says you can use all the resources you need from the lodge, alright? But… The-the storm… They are saying it will last at least two more days. It could be longer— Glimmer apologetically explained. —We can't send anyone to remove the snow and get you out until it stops or recedes enough, at least…*

—I… know. Yes— the young woman sighed, lowering her head. —Thank you for the update. And thank your mother for me— she added. —Ah, I almost forgot: Did Adora feed my pets?

*—Yes, Auntie. They are alright.*

—Good, good. I imagine they must be restless.

*—She said they were walking all around, yeah…*

—I think I understand them— she breathlessly laughed. —At least they all get along…

*—Are you both still in one piece? No one died, right?— Glimmer snickered.*

—Oh, barely. I *swear* I don't know what to do anymore— Castaspella grunted. —I'm pretty sure she hates me for something, but she won't tell me. And if she keeps pestering me, I might go feral…

*—Please don't, Auntie.*

—I won't do anything, *for now*— she chuckled. —But please don't let it be a week…

*—Alright, alright— Glimmer sighed. —As soon as the storm calms down enough, a team will go dig out the snow to unblock the exit. I promise you.*

—Thank you— Castaspella smiled. —Take care, Dear.

*—You too, Auntie. Deep breaths…*

—Deep breaths— she nodded. —Bye.

With a sigh, the young woman hung up and rested back on the seat.

She covered her face with both hands and brushed down her face, groaning.

Deep breaths…

Deep…

A sudden loud noise, something shattering, startled Castaspella and made her jump from the seat.

What the *heck* had happened?

Did Shadow Weaver break something?

Muffled swearing reached her ears, confirming her suspicions, and she didn't hesitate to rush out of the office.

It seemed like she was on the second floor.

Why on Etheria was she up there instead of having breakfast or something!? It's just the storeroom, full of discarded boxes and old furniture!

She didn't know, and didn't care… but it was better to go take a look.

Castaspella ran upstairs and was shocked to find the woman struggling to cover a broken window with a large piece of cardboard.

Just *great*.

—Stay *there*, you little piece of *shit*!

—What the fuck happened here!?

—Help first, questions later!— Shadow Weaver barked, trying to reach for an adhesive paper tape roll on a nearby stand.

Right! Right…

It took her a moment to finally react and go for the tape, but soon she was sticking pieces of tape over the cardboard to fix it in place. After a few minutes, all four sides were completely sealed, and the chilly wind of the storm no longer leaked inside.

—Alright…— Castaspella sighed, gasping for air after all the effort. —*What* happened? What were you- Holy shit! You're bleeding!— she began asking, until she looked back at her and noticed her shoulder.

—Just a scratch— Shadow Weaver tried to dismiss her.

It was *most definitely* not “a scratch” and she knew it.

She couldn’t see the shards of glass stuck on her skin, but she could *feel them*.

—Bullshit! Let me take a look…

—Unless you know how to treat wounds, leave me alone— the old woman snarled, looking a lot like a cornered animal.

—I usually help the nurse, alright? Trust me on this— Castaspella tried to reassure her, carefully approaching. —Come on. Let’s go to the restrooms or the nurse’s office. I’ll patch you up, and you can tell me what happened.

Shadow Weaver was hesitant, reluctant to trust her… but she had no other choice and eventually gave in.

They quietly reached the nurse’s office and the young woman had her sit on the stretcher while she grabbed some supplies: hydrogen peroxide, some gauze, cotton, thiomersal…

However, upon closer inspection, Castaspella finally saw the shards of glass stuck on her shoulder, and grabbed another couple of tools: pincers, suture thread, and needle.

—Wa-wait, *what*!?

—You’ll need stitches for that— the woman seriously replied.

—You’re *not* sewing my shoulder!

—Just a few stitches! Calm down! Ugh…

—You are *not* a nurse!

Right…

Rolling her eyes, Castaspella just turned to see if there was some lidocaine or bupivacaine at least; there had to be *something* she could inject as local anesthesia.

Fortunately, they were both available.

—Alright, woman. Listen: I *have* to suture your wound, like it or not. So cooperate with me a bit— she pleaded. —About the stitches hurting, don’t worry, I’ll apply some local anesthesia first. But you decide whether I’ll use the one that lasts longer and hurts more when I inject it or the one that’s less painful but lasts less time too— she carefully explained. —I don’t offer a mix because I’m not *that* knowledgeable…

Shadow Weaver’s expression went from outraged to surprised and finally resigned.

—The one that lasts longer. I can take more pain *now*, but I'm not good at bearing it through long periods…— she eventually requested.

Then bupivacaine it was.

—Alright. I'll first give you the injection and then remove the glass while it takes effect— Castaspella gently explained.

A short while after, about five shards of glass were sitting on a Petri dish nearby while the old woman observed Castaspella carefully suture the cleansed wound without feeling anything.

However, she still complained a lot.

—…Had you even done this before? Or am I being used for practice here?

—What part of "don't anger the person digging a needle into your shoulder" did you not understand the first few times?— she muttered, seething yet refusing to be so petty as to hurt Shadow Weaver on purpose.

—You didn't answer the question.

—I have experience sewing and have seen the nurse stitching people's wounds enough times. Alright?

—Then I'm an experiment. *Great*.

Oh, it would be so easy to drop everything and walk away…

—I swear. You need only two more. If you don't want me to leave you to your own devices with a needle through your shoulder, then *fucking stop* and let me finish these stitches!— Castaspella severely stated.

—Right… I just…

—You're just being a baby, and have no faith in me whatsoever. You really think I'm useless and don't trust I can do this, even when you've been watching me all this time— the woman interrupted her, notoriously offended. —Will you tell me why you hate me so much? Why do you have such a low opinion of me!?

—It doesn't matter— she replied, looking away. For some reason, she still refused to disclose the truth. So instead, she recalled —But you wanted to know what happened with the window…

—How did part of it end in your shoulder?

—I fell and hit it…

—Did you trip down?

—Not exactly— she denied, clearing her throat. —I was looking outside to see whether the storm was still going and searching for signs of it receding. Then I heard a strange noise behind me, and when I turned to check what it was, a roach jumped on me.

Castaspella couldn't help giggling, imagining the situation, but quickly pushed back her laughter as she fetched the scissors to cut the extra thread.

She was done.

—I had no idea there were roaches here… and with these low temperatures— she commented, trying to dissimulate how amused she was.

—Well, there was at least one— Shadow Weaver insisted, gritting her teeth.

—I'm not saying the opposite. Don't get mad— the young woman pointed out, picking up everything she used to store it all back in its place after putting a final patch of gauze over the stitches. Once that was settled, she sighed —Alright. I think we need breakfast. And a change of clothes…

—This shirt should probably be discarded… it's bloodied and torn— she scoffed.

—Of course not. You'll give me that, I'll fix it, and it's going with the laundry— Castaspella countered.

Right, why not?

Rolling her eyes, the old woman could only think about how lucky she was to be using those clothes from the lodge instead of her own.

If her expensive burgundy winter dress had been torn instead, she wouldn't give two fucks about her shoulder.

She'd rather die… maybe.

Well, that'd be an exaggeration, but it would certainly be a tragedy for her.

A while later, back in the main hall, Castaspella insisted the old woman rested on the couch while she prepared breakfast for them both.

—Why would you do that? How many favours do you want me to owe you?— Shadow Weaver complained.

—You owe me nothing!— she indignantly replied. —Did I ever say…

—You don't have to say it.

—Bullshit. I just wouldn't *really* leave you to your own devices when I can help make sure it wouldn't infect or anything!

—Well. You certainly have no reasons to prepare breakfast for me too— she insisted, squinting.

—No. But I want to. You can't use your left arm for now, and you *really* need food after losing that much blood first thing in the morning…— the young woman argued. —Besides, it's nothing. I swear. You owe me nothing…

With that, Castaspella left for the kitchen, leaving a very confused Shadow Weaver standing alone in the middle of the main hall.

After a while, she returned, yawning, and made her way to her couch, without noticing how the old woman was still struggling to take off the bloodied shirt.

—Ah… I- Uh… I need… *help*— she hesitantly uttered, looking in physical pain as she said so.

And Castaspella's expression of shock almost made her regret it.

But she quickly reacted.

—Oh, right! I didn't think…— she began saying, yet trailed off as she rushed to assist Shadow Weaver. Once the shirt was off, she saw her shivering as she reached for her dress and asked —Need help putting it on too?

—Perhaps…

—Sure.

The winter dress was long and made of a really soft tightly-knit burgundy thread that Castaspella couldn't help but admire.

Yet she had to focus.

With care, she helped the woman pass her numb arm through the sleeve, and let her handle the other; then it was time to help her put on her boots before giving her a hand to stand up.

—Can you pass me the belt?

—Allow me— she replied, taking the black leather belt from the couch and fixing it around Shadow Weaver's waist. —There. Now go to the dining room. Breakfast must be almost ready.

—You… haven't changed clothes yet— she awkwardly pointed out.

—I'll be ready soon. You just wait…

—Alright— she finally complied, sounding tired.

As she left the main hall, Castaspella set the torn shirt on the armrest of her couch, quickly undressed, put on her gray shirt, blue sweater, and dark blue pants, then finally donned her

boots and rushed to the kitchen.

—Food’s ready!— the young woman proudly announced, walking into the dining room with a full tray. As she set it down on the table in front of a *very* surprised Shadow Weaver, she happily said —Sweet rolls and coffee.

The old woman remained silent while Castaspella passed her a plate with a roll and then a steamy mug. She stared for a moment, mouth watering with the sweet smell of it alone, and hesitantly took a fork.

—This…— she mumbled, chewing. —It’s not bad— she admitted, clearing her throat after swallowing.

—I’ll take the compliment…— Castaspella sighed, sipping her coffee.

—You did these with the rice cooker again?

—Yes!— she nodded, almost beaming. —Better than the oven. I just put them to cook and needn't stay around to keep an eye on them, as the cooker turns off on its own.

—I'm starting to think you're just lazy…

—Mean…

—You can't *always* cook on that machine.

—I like doing other stuff while cooking instead of sitting around just *waiting*.

—There's this thing called “patience”, you know…— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—Good to know you're feeling better already— Castaspella simply replied, rolling her eyes.

She hadn't noticed, but she was, in fact, feeling better. The anesthesia was still in effect, her stomach no longer empty, and now that she was comfortable in her clothes again, she *really* felt well.

And this was all thanks to the young woman: she patched her up, cooked breakfast, and even helped her get dressed.

It left Shadow Weaver thinking. And feeling… strange.

She didn't like that feeling.

She also disliked the silence that settled between them…

—You… asked earlier why I hate you— she began, unsure. She didn't want to talk about it before, yet she was curious now. —But I thought *you* hated me.

—Well, I don't. Actually, I don't have such strong opinions about you at all— Castaspella promptly denied. —Or, well, I *do* hate your attitude sometimes. But not *you* as a person— she admitted. —Whatever makes you think I hate you?

—You don't remember, do you?

—Ah… Remember what?— the woman sighed, setting down her cup.

—Seven years ago… The trial— Shadow Weaver muttered, looking down at the food. It was so good… she could only hope reminding her wouldn't make Castaspella change her mind and take back the breakfast. —Your testimony sent me to jail for five years.

—I… know— the young woman recognized, looking down and a bit ashamed. She had almost forgotten. *Almost*. —But I didn't even know you at the time. I was just called to testify about Catra's wounds and behaviour. All I cared about was her safety; she showed signs of mistreatment and deserved better. I only spoke the truth for her sake, not to throw *you* in jail. I had nothing personal against you— she concluded.

—So you didn't oppose having me working here after I got out?

—Why would I!?— Castaspella reacted, almost offended. —Look, I… I found it awkward, at first, yes. I mean… I wondered how could anyone be so cruel to a child, considered I'd never understand someone like that, and then, after five years, it turned out that you became my coworker. You're just a person, you made… awful mistakes, but I think it's a good thing that you're being given a chance to return to society and be better— she explained. —I had to keep an eye on you and make sure you never interact with kids, but that was…

—Wait, what!? Did Angella give you that order!?— the woman interrupted, indignant.

—Yes…

—That treacherous angel… I knew she was faking it— she angrily muttered.

—Wait, wait. It's not that she doesn't trust you— Castaspella quickly tried to clarify.

—It's clear *no one* trusts me. I've been labeled a monster and that's what you all think of me — she insisted. —Allowing me to work here is just her charity act! Pretending to be oh-so-magnanimous!

—No, no. Stop that. You're not a charity case, and we *do* trust you learnt your lesson— the young woman remarked. —You're not under vigilance or anything. I meant to say that, since your conditional freedom requires you to stay away from minors, Angella asked me and some of the others to make sure you're never forced into situations where you *have* to interact with kids and put your freedom at risk— she carefully explained. —We can see you always steer clear from children, so we just… try to help however we can.

—Help…— Shadow Weaver sighed. —Why?

—I told you: we think you already had enough. You learnt your lesson and deserve a second chance.

—I'm sure Catra wouldn't agree— she scoffed.

—Well, I mean… If that were the case, she wouldn't even come to the lodge— Castaspella pointed out. —I don't know what she thinks, she never mentions you, and, *fortunately*, you've never crossed paths in the past two years. The important thing is that you regret what you did, don't you?

—Even if I said I do, you *can't* know if that's true.

—I- No, well… but… uh…

—You can drop it— the woman bitterly laughed. —It doesn't matter.

—It does…

—No. Forget it— Shadow Weaver insisted, and finished her sweet roll.

That day passed fast.

They hardly spoke anymore afterwards, had lunch at different times, since the old woman was asleep while Castaspella ate her stew, and later she was having a bath while Shadow Weaver had her portion.

It wasn't until nighttime that they finally interacted again.

—Really!? You want to… cook dinner? But your arm…

—I can move it perfectly fine now. It stings, but it's bearable— the woman assured her. —I just want some soup instead of stew again.

—Oh, right… I see— Castaspella sighed, awkward. —Well, then, sure! I can show you how to use the rice cooker for that— she accepted.

—Much appreciated.

She froze for a second.

—You just… thanked me?

—Don't sound so surprised— Shadow Weaver groaned, rolling her eyes.

—No, I'm- Sorry, I just- Um, you're welcome— she stammered.

—This is why I never thank people… they look at me like I suddenly grew a pair of antlers.

—That'd be less surprising from you— Castaspella giggled.

—Funny…

—Alright. Let's go. You handle the soup preparation and I'll set up the rice cooker— she cheerfully said, making her way to the kitchen.

A while later, both were in the dining room again, each with a bowl of creamy soup, eating in silence.

It turned out to be pretty tasty and Castaspella looked delighted.

Of course, Shadow Weaver pretended she didn't notice, but felt quite proud in a heartwarming way that was extremely foreign to her.

Once their bowls were empty, the young woman insisted on doing the dishes herself and ushered her back to the main hall.

—I cooked just fine. Why are you treating me like a baby again?— she complained.

—I am not! But repetitive movements like what we do when washing dishes will put stress on your shoulder!

—I swear, if you *ever* complain about having to do everything…

—I won't. I am telling you to go rest. It's not a trap to make you feel guilty later, nor is it a way to have you owe me! Stars!

Castaspella was little by little starting to unravel the wild thought process of Shadow Weaver.

And she was certainly starting to worry…

—I'll hold you to it— the old woman eventually accepted, before leaving for the main hall.

By the time she finished with the dishes and got ready to go to sleep, it was evident that the effect of the anesthesia on Shadow Weaver's shoulder had worn out long ago.

She was insufferable again.

—Alright, enough— Castaspella finally interrupted her, in the middle of an angry fit. —You're bothered by *everything* now; the blankets, the clothes, the goddamned heaters and lights! If you're in pain, just *say it*! I can bring you some painkillers!

—Who says I'm in pain!? And why would you even *care*!?— she barked from her couch.

—I say so! Because I'm not stupid! You're terrible, but not *this bad*! After two nights and days, I can tell this irritability is due to pain!

—You're making assumptions. And you didn't answer: why the fuck would *you* care!?

—Why *wouldn't* I!?

—You have no reasons!

—Neither did I have reasons to patch you up, cook, or even be nice to you at all!

—And, finally, we agree!

The sudden silence made them both realize they had been raising their voices, and their yelling resonated in the large hall.

—Enough…— Castaspella uttered, standing up and promptly leaving.

Shadow Weaver was left alone for a while, wondering if the young woman had gone to sleep somewhere else or what, until she returned with a glass of water and something in her closed hand.

—What?

—Just take the pill— she ordered, looking away but still gentle enough.

—Fine…

—Do you need anything else?

—If you know how to make someone fall asleep soon, then share the knowledge— she mockingly replied.

—I can't fall asleep easily myself, but I guess I always put Glimmer to rest with a story— Castaspella considered, thinking aloud.

—You'll tell me a story? And leave the end for tomorrow so I don't kill you tonight?— the old woman teased her.

—What!?

—It's a reference to… Never mind.

Her bewildered expression kept Shadow Weaver from explaining the joke, since it was clear she hadn't caught the reference because she didn't even know the source material.

—Alright— Castaspella sighed, extending the word. —I don't even have any stories to tell, so even if that could work, I have nothing. So… Tea? There should be some chamomile in the kitchen.

—I'll take the tea, yes.

---

## Sunday

The following morning was… far from great.

Castaspella woke up hearing constant whining, and it was no surprise to find Shadow Weaver as the source.

It was worrisome…

The woman was still asleep, it seemed, the patch on her shoulder soaked in blood, and the new thermal shirt she had on would be stained soon. She would *hate it*, but she had to wake her up…

—Um… hey…— Castaspella awkwardly began, placing a hand on her unhurt shoulder. —We need to change your bandage…

—No…

—It *will* start spilling blood soon if you don't let me change it— she insisted.

—I don't… want…— Shadow Weaver mumbled, without opening her eyes.

It felt off.

Just hearing her whining was strange, but the way she was speaking now…

Castaspella had a sudden thought and placed a hand on her forehead, only to let out a gasp.

She was burning up with a fever!

—Shit! Get up! O-or not, stay there, and I'll bring you something…

—What?

—Fever, woman! You're… Ah… Never mind. Just stay there— Castaspella sighed. She rushed to the nurse's office, gathered everything she'd need, and returned, saying —Alright. You need to drink plenty of water and some paracetamol might help with the fever. So you take this, and I'll handle changing your bandage.

Shadow Weaver felt so sick and confused that she didn't even question the young woman. She accepted the paracetamol and the glass of water she offered her, then tried not to move while Castaspella removed the bloodied patch covering her stitches, and quietly bore the reproaches about having slept on that shoulder, causing the stitches to bleed.

—I didn't notice…

—At least it doesn't look infected… I feared for a moment I had done something wrong. Between your fever and the bleeding…— the young woman admitted, shaking her head slightly. —But it's alright. Don't worry. Just rest.

—I… Uh… You really don't need to do all of this…

—You have high temperature and stitches that are *not* professional in the slightest. I don't *need* to do this but I want to and, morally speaking, I *have to*.

—Of course you don’t— Shadow Weaver groaned. —I should take care of myself.

—Can’t you just accept the help? You need *rest*— Castaspella insisted. —I’m not going to charge you for the treatment, nor will I ask for any favours in return— she repeated.

—So you say now…— the old woman muttered, just observing as a new patch of gauze was fixed over the stitches. —But every time I see those stitches, the scar that will be left, I’ll be reminded of this and how much I owe you…

—You owe me nothing, really…— Castaspella sighed, shaking her head. —If you hadn’t been trapped with me, I'd have succumbed to panic long ago— she reminded her. —So… you like the favours system so much: well, you owe me nothing because this is repayment, then.

It was… repayment?

She hadn’t thought about that…

If that was the case, then, maybe, it wasn’t really that bad?

It was clear that, regardless of the past, Castaspella wasn’t trying to undermine her in any way.

Perhaps it was just as she said, nothing personal…

Without realizing it, Shadow Weaver had been staring at her for a while now.

As Castaspella raised a brow, questioning, she finally nodded —Right.

—Good. Now rest here, I’ll bring you some breakfast.

—Sure…

The young woman walked into the kitchen giggling.

It was *wild* having such a complying Shadow Weaver now. She had to be feeling worse than awful…

It was amusing, but also worrisome, to think that the old woman had such terrible trust issues that, even with glass shards on her shoulder, she would have preferred being alone here.

At least it meant the problem wasn’t Castaspella…

She didn’t have a personal issue with her, even if she had been the reason why she got sent to jail…

Ah… it was less than ideal, in any case. If things had been the other way around, she wouldn’t want her anywhere near her either…

Enough pondering.

Food was almost ready.

—Hey…— Castaspella gently called, trying to wake her up. —I brought you breakfast— she told her, once the woman opened her eyes. —Can you sit?

—Yeah— she groggily replied, pushing herself up. —Ugh, my head…

—Slowly. Don't rush.

—Shouldn't that pill from earlier be taking effect already?

—It should, but you must be hungry, which can cause headaches too— she explained, placing the tray on Shadow Weaver's lap.

—Why on Etheria do you know so much about medicine?

—I don't really know that much. I just picked up stuff from helping the nurse, I swear— she giggled. —Tell me if you need help.

—I *better* be able to eat on my own, or I'll have to ask you to put me down…

—Oh, don't exaggerate like that— Castaspella replied, rolling her eyes. —You have a fever, and if I could find the thermometer we'd at least know how bad it is. But we don't so we have to guess it's bad enough to incapacitate you…

—I am *not* incapacitated— the old woman angrily rebuked. —Quit worrying— she then muttered, looking ashamed.

—I didn't mean to make you uncomfortable… I apologize.

—Just forget it.

Castaspella took a deep breath and sighed as she finally went to sit on her couch.

That was when she realized she had forgotten her breakfast in the kitchen, but right as she stood up to get it, the landline rang.

—I'll get it… Hopefully it's good news— she said, wanting to be optimistic. However, as she stepped into the office, her expression darkened as she admitted to herself it was probably more bad news. Resting a hand next to the phone, she picked up and sighed —Hello? Glimmer?

—*Not this time.*

—Angella?

*—I meant to call yesterday, but I couldn't. I'm sorry you've been trapped there the past few days— she apologetically began. —I hope you haven't had a hard time— she then added.*

—We're… fine. I mean…— Castaspella hesitated. —Yesterday, after I hung up with Glimmer, Shadow Weaver fell on the second floor and broke a window— she briefly explained.

*—Really!? Is she hurt!?*

—Yes. I had to… give her a few stitches.

*—Wait, what!? You're not qualified for that!*

—I know! But I had no choice!

*—You do understand she can easily sue us if the wound gets infected or anything!?*

—That's… what you're worried about?— the young woman inquired, genuinely confused.

*—No, no. I'm obviously concerned about her, but if her probation officer brings it up…*

—Angella, calm down. I don't think she will…

*—We can't be sure— she insisted. —But we'll have to solve that later. For now, just… be patient with her. Glimmer told me you've been struggling a bit, and I can't imagine how much worse it has become since the wound.*

—Ah, well. She got quite irritable after the anesthesia wore off, and I basically had to force her to take a painkiller— Castaspella recalled. —But it's much better, actually. We could speak the other day and… clarified a few things.

*—Really?*

—Well, I know now why I felt like she hated me. And… I guess she doesn't; she just disliked me with all due reason— the woman explained, standing up straighter as her back started to hurt. —And she may have gotten a bit upset about your order to keep an eye on her, you know? The matter is settled now, but I wanted to tell you in case she ever brings it up.

*—I'm surprised she never noticed, actually. But yes, I expect her to complain next time I see her— Angella sighed. —Well, it's good to know you're coexisting just fine, at least.*

—Yes. I suppose the only reason to need help as soon as possible now would be to get a real doctor to check her wound.

*—Of course… About that: I'm sorry to say that you can expect at least another day before someone can go dig out the exit— she apologized. —With some luck, tomorrow afternoon the storm will have calmed enough.*

—Right— Castaspella nodded, swallowing nervously. —We still have food until then. We should be fine.

*—Alright. Goodbye, then. I'll call tomorrow if I can. Or ask Glimmer if not— Angella farewelled.*

—Bye.

The young woman hung up and covered her face with both hands as she let out an exhausted groan.

Well, it was time for that breakfast now…

—How did the call go? Any news?— Shadow Weaver asked, once Castaspella sat on her couch with her tray.

—Yes… If we're lucky, tomorrow by the afternoon the storm might recede enough for someone to come for us.

—Another day here it is…— the old woman sighed. —How much food do we have left?

—There's still some lentil stew and some of your soup, so we're covered for lunch and dinner. These were the last rolls I made, but breakfast is easy to fix; we still have bread, cheese, eggs, flour…

—Good— she nodded. —In that case, we have one thing less to worry about.

—Yes. Then there's electricity, water, and gas; everything seems to be working just fine for now, so…

—You're finally thinking rationally instead of panicking. Good job— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Mean…

—Speaking of having water, I need a bath— she stated, ignoring the comment. She carefully stood up, feeling a bit dizzy, and picked up the tray.

—Wait, wait. You have to be careful. You mustn't wet the patch on your shoulder, or I'll have to change it again, and we can't keep using that much gauze— Castaspella pointed out. —On the other hand, you also have to be careful if you shower, lest you get lightheaded and fall.

—You can't exactly help me take a bath, so I will have to manage— the woman replied, rolling her eyes.

—N-no! Well, no, I can't but… Try to be careful, alright?

—I think I preferred it when you didn't care about me— she muttered, looking ashamed again.

—Why is it so bad to have someone care about you!? I-I can't believe you can be so frustrating!

—You *don't* have to care. I don't need it! And if I'm so frustrating, then all the more reasons for you to just ignore me— Shadow Weaver insisted, slowly walking away.

—Well, I can't!— Castaspella rebuked, standing up to approach her. —Come on, I'll help you reach the restrooms.

—I said I don't need help…

—And I'm seeing you walk as if the world around you were turning. Just let me help!

—I might be frustrating, but you can be insufferable too.

—Well, I'd rather not keep playing nurse… And leave the tray, I'll pick it up later.

She wasn't wrong…

And Shadow Weaver didn't want another accident either.

So she had to comply and let her walk with her to the restrooms, making sure she wouldn't fall.

Which she almost did. Twice.

Lunchtime arrived soon; they silently had the remaining lentil stew, and then Castaspella handled the dishes while the old woman prepared some tea.

—I… Erm, I need to… thank you— Shadow Weaver hesitantly began. —I'm not good at it, but I won't pretend you haven't done anything for me— she went on, looking away while the water heated up. —I won't apologize for what I said earlier, though. I still think you shouldn't care about me or help me further. Yet, despite my complaints, you did, and… it's just petty of me to dismiss it.

—You don't have to thank me if you're not comfortable. I don't mind— the young woman assured her, drying her hands after finishing with the dishes. —I wasn't expecting it, in any case. But, you're welcome.

—Anyways…— she let out, waving a hand dismissively and turning to remove the boiling water from the heat. —I'll have some tea and go to sleep…

—Good idea. You look quite pale.

—You… eh… want some?

—Sure!

Castaspella spent the afternoon knitting while Shadow Weaver slept the fever away.

Eventually, the wool ran out, so the young woman was left alone with her thoughts…

She checked her phone, still no signal, tried to distract herself by playing some offline games, yet lost interest pretty soon and put her phone aside.

And so the fatalistic thoughts began…

What if the storm still raged on the whole of the next day?

What if food ran out?

And if either water, gas, or electricity were cut?

What if… what if… what if…

Shadow Weaver woke up shortly after, probably due to the sound of her pacing around.

—What are you… doing?— she groggily inquired, interrupted by a yawn, too sleepy to notice her distressedness, but curious enough to ask.

—You're awake— she noticed, finally stopping. —Did I…

—Perhaps…

—Sorry. I'm just…

—Panicking again?— the woman interrupted, brushing her eyes. —What's the problem now?

—I'm a bit… worried… that this will keep dragging on for a long time— she shyly explained.

—A bit?— she scoffed. With another yawn, she stood up from the couch, stretched briefly, and told her —You need to distract yourself… Isn't there any more wool in the lost-and-found box? I see you used it all up.

—I can't focus on knitting right now— Castaspella insisted, hugging herself. —I just want to go home— she whimpered, looking down.

Well, damn… What the heck was Shadow Weaver supposed to do now!?

She was absolutely *not* good at comforting people, but she couldn't leave her crying either.

A distraction…

What could she…

—I know— she muttered, as a thought suddenly occurred to her. The radio. The old woman promptly went to turn it on and fiddled with the tuner until she found a station transmitting music. —Come on, now— she invited, approaching.

—What?— Castaspella sniffed.

—Let's distract you until dinner, at least— Shadow Weaver smirked, extending a hand for her to take.

And so she did. Hesitantly, but she did.

The song was quite upbeat, so the old woman pulled her into a silly dance, having her move around, twist and turn, until making her laugh.

Neither had ever imagined they would find themselves laughing and dancing together like that.

No one would believe it either…



After a few songs, Castaspella started to feel tired.

But she was… happy.

Her anxiety now gone, replaced by giddiness.

She hadn't had so much fun in quite a while.

After checking the time, they decided it was a good moment to have dinner at last, and left the radio on as they went to the kitchen for the remaining soup. With the music in the background, they sat in the dining room and, for once, chatted while eating.

—So… what would you be doing if you were at home right now?

—Right now? Sleeping.

—Don't you have any hobbies?— Castaspella asked, baffled but genuinely curious.

—I do but, *specifically at this time today*, I would be sleeping already. It's Sunday, after all…

—Right, you're right— she realized. —I lost track of what day it is— she shyly admitted.

—I reckon— Shadow Weaver smirked. —What about you? What would *you* be doing if you were at home?

The young woman was taken aback for a moment. She wasn't expecting her to show interest.

But… it would probably make her regret it if Castaspella expressed her surprise, so she hid it behind a smile.

—I'd be having some tea, knitting or reading, as I'd probably be unable to fall asleep— she told her. —Not much different from what I've been doing here- Well, I don't have books here, though, but I've been knitting.

—It was clearly a good idea to tell you about that stuff in the box— the old woman briefly laughed.

—Oh, so it was just a strategy to keep me occupied?

—Obviously…

—But you still knew my interests— Castaspella pointed out, folding her arms and looking pretty smug. —Means you've paid attention.

—As I told you, you keep gifting your niece those ugly sweaters, and making quite a fuss about it— Shadow Weaver replied, dismissing her "accusations". —I'd have to be *very* oblivious not to put two and two together…

—It's more than- I mean, hardly anyone notices anything about me, you know? So even if it was unintentional…

—You're giving it too much meaning— she interrupted her, refusing to admit she had been paying her any attention.

No, no.

She couldn't- It was ridiculous.

Why would she pay attention- Well, she did have a certain fixation, but it wasn't for good reasons.

She was resentful and mostly kept trying to spot all and any flaws Castaspella could have.

It was petty, yes, but… she just did.

—Never mind… I guess it's not important— the young woman finally sighed, giving up. —But, thanks anyways. Even if it was because you wanted to keep me busy so that I wouldn't bother you… it actually helped me a lot.

—Don't mention it…— Shadow Weaver dismissed it, incidentally ruining Castaspella's mood completely. No, she didn't mean to, but she did. And once she looked back at her, it was impossible to ignore. She was looking away, quiet, with a disheartened expression. The old woman had no idea why it bothered her so much, or why she herself was feeling a pang of guilt now, but that made her try to fix it, asking —So, tell me, what kind of books do you read?

—Um… a bit of everything— she shyly replied, still looking away. —Novels, mostly fantasy and science fiction. Then I also read plays, both tragedies and comedies. But also some general knowledge stuff from some encyclopedias I got— she enumerated. Then, more cheerful, she finally looked back as she added —Oh! And more specific reference books on arachnids!

—That's… quite niche. Why arachnids?

—Because I keep pet spiders— she casually replied.

—*What*?— Shadow Weaver asked, stunned.

—Yeah… I know, it's… weird.

—I thought you'd have… cats or something like that— she admitted.

—Many do— Castaspella giggled. —I don't know why.

—When you think about it, spiders do make sense, but I suppose it's so rare for someone to keep them as pets instead of… killing them on sight, that no one would ever guess— Shadow Weaver considered.

—Oh, I hate it when people kill spiders— she grunted. —They aren't that bad! They keep most invasive insects in check, like mosquitoes and flies; they don't bother you if you don't bother them… They are *so* respectful!

—If you say so…

—I mean it! They are basically the opposite of cockroaches— she insisted, disgusted. —Those are *treacherous*, will walk over you or fly to your face just because, and can be so filthy!

—On that, I must agree— the old woman nodded. —If I could, I'd definitely burn them on sight.

Castaspella let out a hearty laugh, almost covering her mouth.

—Pretty much, yes!

When she looked at Shadow Weaver again, she surprised her smiling and couldn't help gasping.

It was just… so unexpected.

And heartwarming even.

—Do I have something on my face?

—N-no… I mean… Kind of— Castaspella giggled, looking away. —I've never seen you smile. Only smirk sardonically or such…

—I was not smiling— she refuted, squinting at her.

—You were; I wouldn't believe it if I hadn't seen it.

—You are hallucinating. Must be too tired…

—I am not! You're in denial!

—Uh-huh, sure— Shadow Weaver let out, rolling her eyes while standing and picking up her bowl. —I think it's time to clean up and go to sleep…

—Right— the young woman agreed. She followed her into the kitchen, carrying her bowl too, and offered —Let me do the dishes. I think you still need to rest your arm.

—It hasn't hurt lately. I think I'm fine.

—I insist. Better not to strain it.

—Fine…— she eventually complied, albeit with a groan. —I'll get changed then.

—Want some tea?

—I'll prepare it in a few minutes.

—I can do it.

—Allow me to do *something* or I might as well go insane— Shadow Weaver complained. —I feel babied every time you do things for me— she admitted, folding her arms.

—Sorry… Alright. I'll focus on the dishes then.

A while later, Castaspella had just finished changing into the thermal clothes when the woman walked into the main hall with two steamy mugs. She gave her one and then went to her couch to sit with hers, looking quite tired.

After a few minutes of silence, with only the music of the radio filling the room, she suddenly asked —Do you think Angella will charge us for all the supplies we've been using?

—She told me we can use whatever we need, so she better not…— Castaspella replied. —I mean… have we even used that much?

—We have, actually— Shadow Weaver uttered, disgruntled. —Half the teabags, almost all the tomato sauce, most of the vegetables, as well as the coffee filters and grains.

—You're kidding me.

—I checked while the water was heating up. We don't have provisions for much longer, so this storm better recede tomorrow— she scowled.

—I hope so…

Castaspella let out a long sigh and picked up her phone, which still couldn't catch any signal, to open her gallery. Having told the woman about her spiders made her miss them, and so she went through their pictures, smiling sadly at her screen.

—What's got you so melancholic all of a sudden?— Shadow Weaver asked, curious.

—I'm just… missing my babies.

—Your spiders?

—Yes.

—You're looking at pictures of them?— she inquired, incredulous.

—Precisely! Do you… want to see them?

—Erm…— she hesitated, unsure. —Sure, why not… I'm kind of curious— she finally admitted.

With a bright smile, Castaspella stood up and went to sit by her side to show her the photos.

—This is the biggest one. It's quite protective of the others, even the ones older than it— she began, briefly sipping her tea. —Then this one is the oldest; it is like five years old…

—They can live that long?

—Well, in captivity, they can even reach two decades, actually…

—That's insane.

—Then there's these little ones— she went on, smiling fondly. —They were born last week!

—How many do you have?

—Well, I have three terrariums, and each has between ten and fifteen spiders, depending on their size. So, with these new ones… About forty.

—What the heck!?

—They have a lot of offspring, so…

—How do you feed so many? How do you even keep track of them?

—Oh, I… don't. I mean, keep track of them. They don't have names, actually— she explained, looking away for a moment and setting down her mug. —And feeding them is quite easy, you know? You can just buy crickets, fruit flies, and mealworms for them in pet stores or online— she went on.

—Wait. Aren't pets usually named?

—I… Yeah, well, I don't— she admitted, looking down.

—Why?

—I was… taught not to name them. Most of them live less than a year, so, if I don't name them, I don't- I won't say I "don't grieve them", I do, but I suffer a bit less, I guess. I don't get so attached.

Shadow Weaver was shocked for a moment.

—I absolutely did *not* expect you to have that… uh, *philosophy*.

—I know— she sighed. —But it's for the best.

—Who taught you that?— the old woman inquired, interested.

—My late mentor. I actually adopted her spiders after she passed.

—I see…

—Oh, but you have to see the webs they spin! They can be gorgeous— Castaspella suddenly remembered, almost beaming.

The way she changed subjects took Shadow Weaver aback, but she decided to roll with it.

They were probably getting into a sensitive subject…

—Those are quite elaborated— she commented, looking at the pictures as the young woman passed them, while calmly sipping her tea. —But if they don't catch food with them, why do they make them?

—I try to create the illusion that they do trap them and usually drop the fruit flies on them. But they seem to just *like* sitting on them instead of being on the ground. So perhaps they use them the same way we use hammocks!

—That makes sense, I guess— she chuckled.

Castaspella gave her a soft look, appreciating her interest.

It made Shadow Weaver suddenly aware of how close they were sitting, for the first time since they worked together, and it froze her.

—Are you alright?

—I- Yes.

—A-are you uncomfortable?— she stammered, also noticing their proximity.

—It's the opposite, actually. That's why I'm… surprised.

—Oh.

Now it was time for Castaspella to be frozen.

How could she answer to that?

Swallowing hard and looking away, the old woman sighed —Forget I said anything. You can… return to your couch if you prefer.

—I-I'm fine. I… would like to stay here if you still want to talk.

—Right… Sure.

—So, um… do you have pets? Or had or want to have?

—I had cats when I was younger. Haven't had any more pets in over a decade… And I don't know if I will ever get any again…

---

## Monday

Oblivious to the time, the women kept on chatting until well past midnight; when the teas were gone, they placed the mugs on the floor near the couch and kept on talking.

Around four in the morning, Castaspella began falling asleep, resting on her side against the back of the couch and, for some reason, Shadow Weaver didn't send her away. Maybe because she was too tired herself; she didn't even turn off the radio…

Hence, a few hours later, when the phone rang, the young woman was surprised to find herself in such a strange position, occupying half of *that* couch instead of the one she had claimed, and with music in the background.

The phone kept ringing as she stared at the sleeping Shadow Weaver until she managed to snap out of it and drag herself to the office.

—Hello?— she groggily answered.

*—Good afternoon, Auntie— Glimmer greeted her.*

—Afternoon!?

*—It's almost one.*

—Oh, damn.

*—So you just woke up!?*

—Yes…

*—Alright, I'll be brief— her niece decided. —The storm is finally calming down! You can expect a team to be there in three hours and begin removing the snow— she announced. —They said it can take between an hour and two, so you should be out by six, hopefully!*

—Really!? That's great!

*—Of course, that's only if the weather remains stable all afternoon, but the forecast assures as much— Glimmer clarified.*

—Then I hope they are right— Castaspella sighed. —We actually noticed last night that some supplies are running out…

*—Oh, just in time then!— she realized. —Alright, I think that's all. See you soon!*

—See you soon, Dear— she farewelled, before hanging up.

At long last!

The woman rushed out of the office to tell Shadow Weaver the good news, quite excited, and both seemed relieved it would finally be over.

Four nights locked up there…

It had been insane at times, passable sometimes, and, on a few rare occasions, enjoyable.

But it would be over at last.

After changing the old woman's patch on her shoulder with the last remains of gauze they had, Castaspella prepared breakfast for them both while Shadow Weaver brewed some coffee again.

They took everything to the dining room and silently sat to eat.

—These, uh… These pancakes are good— the old woman hesitantly said after a while of silence.

She simply couldn't bear it anymore.

—Hmm, good to know.

—I reckon you used the last eggs?

—Yeah…

—The good thing is that the lodge probably won't be opening for a few days, so we will have time to restock— she then considered.

—Ah, true. I suppose we won't return to work until the other week.

—Hopefully.

—You think Angella would open sooner?

—I think she will as soon as all supplies have been replenished, yes— she nodded.

—Please no…

—We can always ask for the rest of the week after this— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —We deserve it.

—Under what arguments?

—Compensation for occupational hazards.

—That's ridiculous, but… worth a shot— Castaspella giggled.

—If it works, it works. I won't sue her for compensatory damages, but she should still give us the week, at the very least.

—Yeah…

—And if she doesn't, I'll just fake a fever or something— the woman added, smirking.

—Not surprised you would— she snickered.

—Should I be offended?

—No, no… Well, maybe a bit— Castaspella admitted, giggling.

—You're lucky I won't take offence, solely because I admit it's a very *me* thing to do.

—Self-aware, huh?

—Absolutely.

—I think that's a good thing— the young woman smiled. —Once you're aware of what you do, you can work on changing bad behaviours.

—If I want to…— Shadow Weaver remarked.

—Right.

—Fortunately, I have gotten rid of most *undesirable* behaviours already— she sighed. —That's why I'm out.

—I can't even imagine how bad that was, then…

—You don't want to know— the woman bitterly laughed, getting a piece of pancake into her mouth.

—Well, then, I'm glad I got to know this, uh, reformed version of you, at least— Castaspella commented. —I admit I thought… you were worse.

—Fair. I was sure you were just a foolish girl playing adult…— Shadow Weaver replied, brutally honest. —You'll be glad to know I no longer think so.

—Then what do you think now?

—I… suppose you *are* as smart as I was told, even if you need a little help to channel that, but remain a bit of a foolish woman; you can be quite silly— she mocked her. —It isn't always a bad thing, though; it's amusing and breaks the monotony of the serious adult world…

—Hmm… Well, you're certainly not as bad as I thought— she smiled, not even offended by the "foolish and silly" bits. —You just put up that cold and mean act to *appear* worse than you are.

—If you tell anyone I'm "not that bad", I won't speak to you again— Shadow Weaver immediately threatened.

—Wow, alright— Castaspella reacted, raising her hands in surrender. —I won't ruin your reputation, don't worry— she laughed.

—Better…

After doing the dishes, the young woman returned to the main hall, lowered the radio's volume slightly, and went to sit on her couch, trying to decide how to occupy her time until lunch.

However, Shadow Weaver soon appeared, bringing a deck of cards she found in the lost-and-found box.

—Oh, I recall seeing that the other day— Castaspella remembered. —Do you know how to play deck fights?

—Of course I do— she replied, smug. —And I'm pretty good, if I say so myself…

—Huh… So am I!

—Are you officially challenging me?

—Maybe…— she smirked, unable to hold back a giggle. —Let's play and see who's better; the loser prepares lunch.

—Deal— Shadow Weaver accepted, matching her smirk. —Dining room?

—Sure. More comfortable— she nodded. —Just let me get changed.

—I'll wait there.

Castaspella rushed to put on her clothes and soon took her place at the table in front of the old woman. After dealing the cards, the first round began, and they both focused on bringing their best game.

Much to Shadow Weaver's surprise, the young woman was pretty good… Perhaps *too* good.

After narrowly losing again, she couldn't help but slam her hands down on the table while she happily celebrated —Yes! Another round for me! Woo-hoo!

—How on Etheria are you *this* good!?

—It's my favourite game!

—That explains *nothing*…

—I am not as petty as you, so I will explain: I have played this game since I was old enough to understand its rules, and I have been playing it for *decades* now, meaning I've polished my strategies about as much as humanly possible— Castaspella proudly replied.

—"Humanly possible" being the keyword here— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —I'm far older, enough that I *should* be much better…— she then muttered, angry but at herself.

—It's just a figure of speech. I mean…

—I know what you mean— she interrupted. —It doesn't change shit.

—Wow, alright. Ca-can you calm down?

—No… Forget it— the old woman denied, shaking her head and standing up. —I have some lunch to cook, it seems…

—Wait, wait. You don't have to if you don't want to…— Castaspella tried to stop her, standing up too, worried.

—Rules are rules. You won, I lost.

—But…

—No buts. You don't have to change the rules just because I dislike the outcome.

That made the young woman lower her head and give up on trying to stop her.

—Alright… I'll pick up the cards, then— she finally sighed, unsure of whether Shadow Weaver had heard her.

Almost an hour later, she was finally out of the kitchen.

—I won't take any complaints— she warned, setting a tray down on the table.

—Why would I complain?

—Literally anything. But I don't want to hear it— the old woman insisted, taking a seat.

—You don't have to brace yourself for impact… Calm down a bit— Castaspella tried to reassure her. —This smells delicious, and I'm actually impressed you could make mashed potatoes!

—I wanted to cook omelets, but then remembered you used the last eggs…

—Oops?

—You don't have to answer to *me*…

—I don't even want to think about what Angella will say…— the young woman groaned.

—Rest assured… I'll blame it all on you— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Fuck you!— she laughed. —But this is… really good. I like how the mashed potatoes taste! And the burgers with melted cheese on top are great!

—I'm… uh, glad— she shyly replied.

It made Castaspella smile; the shyness, her acknowledgement, or perhaps it was just noticing the effort she put into the food…

Whatever it was, it made her smile.

It was strange but, at the same time, it felt so nice she was actually glad this had happened; she wouldn't have gotten to know the woman this well, otherwise…

Once the food was gone, they did the dishes together, one washing while the other dried and put them away, and kept on chatting about trivialities.

Once back in the main hall, the young woman went to turn the radio volume a bit higher and invited her —Would you join me?

—Just one song…

—Sure— Castaspella giggled, pulling her into the center of the room as soon as she took her hand. —Oh, but this song is almost ending, next one!

—Why do I feel like you'll find a loophole to make me dance more than one?

—Do *you* want to dance more than one?— she asked back, raising a brow and smirking slightly.

—I said the opposite…

—Yes, but something tells me you *want me* to find a way to make you dance more— she snickered.

—Try your best.

—I shall…

Said and done, the women danced a few songs before taking a break and having some tea.

They found themselves chatting about their interests with a pair of steamy mugs when the sound of voices surprised them.

—Over here! Focus on this area!

Shadow Weaver immediately gave her a look and she asked —Should we call out?

—Not yet, but we should get ready.

—Good idea, yeah…

—I'll turn off the heaters. Can you wash the cups?

—Of course.

Having agreed, the women made quick work of everything and were soon ready to leave, with their coats on and their backpacks closed.

As soon as they could open the door, Castaspella profusely thanked the group of men and women who had dug out the snow, while Shadow Weaver merely grunted.

And so came the time for goodbyes, which, unsurprisingly, were swift and brisk. And awkward, of course…

It made the young woman feel like the last two days had been a fever dream.

As nighttime arrived, they both followed their routines, got into bed eventually, and attempted to sleep…

But it felt so *strange*.

It was actually normal, yet… it felt *lacking*.

Castaspella was used to having trouble falling asleep, so she soon busied herself with some knitting until feeling tired enough.

On the other hand, Shadow Weaver was *not* used to it, and grumpily got up to find some book or something… which didn't help as it reminded her of the young woman and kept her awake for a long while still.

They had no idea, but both seemed to *miss* being trapped together.

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## Following Monday

A week later, the women were back in the lodge, and as soon as the flow of people slowed down, Shadow Weaver called Castaspella to the administrative office, for a little chat.

—Did I or did I not tell you she wouldn't give us the week?

—Yeah, you were right…

—Did you fake a fever?— the old woman asked, curious.

—No, I must… have eaten something bad because I spent a few days throwing up and in bed… I couldn't stand until Friday…

—I'd say it's convenient if it weren't because you look *sorry* you couldn't come to work sooner.

—I feel bad, alright!?— Castaspella argued, blushing. Then, thinking about it, she asked —Did *you* fake a fever?

—Obviously.

—And was that why you sent and deleted so many messages?— she then added, folding her arms.

—No… that was- Ahem, no. I just kept making stupid questions which I could fortunately delete before you saw them— she admitted, looking away.

—Oh. I- Well, I'm kind of curious now…

—Well, die curious, because I'm not telling you— Shadow Weaver quickly retorted, making her laugh. —What's so funny?

—I have the feeling you've been waiting all week to say that— she giggled.

—Right— the old woman scoffed, looking away. —Now: the reason I called you here— she finally recalled, fetching something from her desk. —I believe you'll… find this entertaining.

A book.

—What's…— she began asking, yet trailed off as she read the title. —*Arabian Nights*?

Upon opening the cover, a little note could be read on the first page:

Maybe you'll learn some stories for next time.

~Beatrix

—Well, since you didn't catch the reference I made when we were trapped, I imagine you haven't read it…

—The reference- You mean that thing about not killing me?

—About leaving the end for tomorrow so I wouldn't kill you. It's not- Ugh, never mind…— the old woman grunted, starting to regret it. —Read that and you'll understand. Educate yourself.

—Thanks— Castaspella giggled. —I appreciate it— she let out, before moving forward to hug her.

That was… less than ideal.

Yet far from realizing how stiff and uncomfortable she was, the young woman only doubled down and gave her a quick peck on her cheek.

—What on Etheria are you- Why did you do that!?— Shadow Weaver reacted, still frozen in place, and wondering why she didn't push her away immediately.

—So-sorry. Did I overstep?

—You *think*!?

—I was just- I-I'm sorry. I'm just… thankful…

—Just leave. Now— the woman ordered, looking away.

—Right. Sorry, again…— Castaspella muttered, pressing the book to her chest and rushing out. —Stupid, *stupid*…

She only watched her disappear in absolute confusion, still unable to believe what happened.

And, little did she know, it would haunt her the rest of the day…

By closing time, as expected, only the two of them remained.

However, this time it was… awkward.

Castaspella tried to make quick work of the locks and depart as soon as possible, yet Shadow Weaver had a different idea.

After thinking about it all afternoon, she devised the perfect apology: none at all.

—Leaving already?— she asked, pulling the young woman closer, wrapping an arm around her waist.

—Wha-what are you…

—Doing?— she interrupted, their lips almost brushing. —Hmm… I'm certainly envying whatever book you'll be choosing tonight…

—Sure— Castaspella scoffed, blushing yet refusing to buy it. —You don't really- Pro-prove it.

—What?

—What you just… said…— she barely managed to breathe out, before being surprised by a kiss. It was brief yet lasted just enough for her to kiss Shadow Weaver back. As they parted, she admitted —I'll consider inviting you home someday, to take the place of my book in our little evening date…

—Well, I would certainly like that— the old woman expressed, smirking. —If not, of course… there's always the next storm, right?

With a soft smile, the young woman nodded —Until the next storm…

End Notes

Alright, that was all

Again, this could have been a multi-chapter instead, but… I had decided one-shot 💀

Aaaaaanyways
Did anyone catch the reference to Scheherazade? Ksjsjs

I honestly never know if it's called *Arabian Nights* or *One Thousand and One Nights*, which is the name I know it by in Spanish, but I went with the one that I think is most well known… cause… I don't know…

Aaaaaanyways again!
I hope this was entertaining and at least a bit fun since I actually suck at writing funny things, and obviously failed to make this "short and silly" as intended…

Whatever, I hope you enjoyed and see you somewhere else! Bye!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!